Little Fox Readers

Level 5

JOURNEY to the WEST 63

A Question for Buddha



Little Fox



The Tang Monk jumped to his feet as the villagers hid behind trees. Wukong, Wujing, and Bajie pulled out their weapons.

A large shell rose from the water.

"It's a giant turtle!" said Bajie.

The turtle bowed its head toward Wukong. "That demon had taken over my house and river. Thank you for getting rid of him." The turtle then looked at the villagers.



“You don’t need to make a boat. I can take the travelers across the river.”

“That’s wonderful!” said the Tang Monk. “I’m from the Tang Empire, and—”

“I know who you are,” interrupted the turtle. “You’re traveling to the Western Paradise to get scriptures from Buddha. I knew you would cross my river eventually. Climb onto my shell.”



Wukong eyed the turtle suspiciously. “How do we know we can trust you? Demons all along the way are waiting for my master to pass by.”

“They all want to eat him,” added Bajie.

“I promise I won’t hurt the Tang Monk,” said the turtle. “I want to help him reach the Western Paradise.”

After a little more hesitation, the travelers



stepped onto the turtle's shell. The turtle began to paddle.

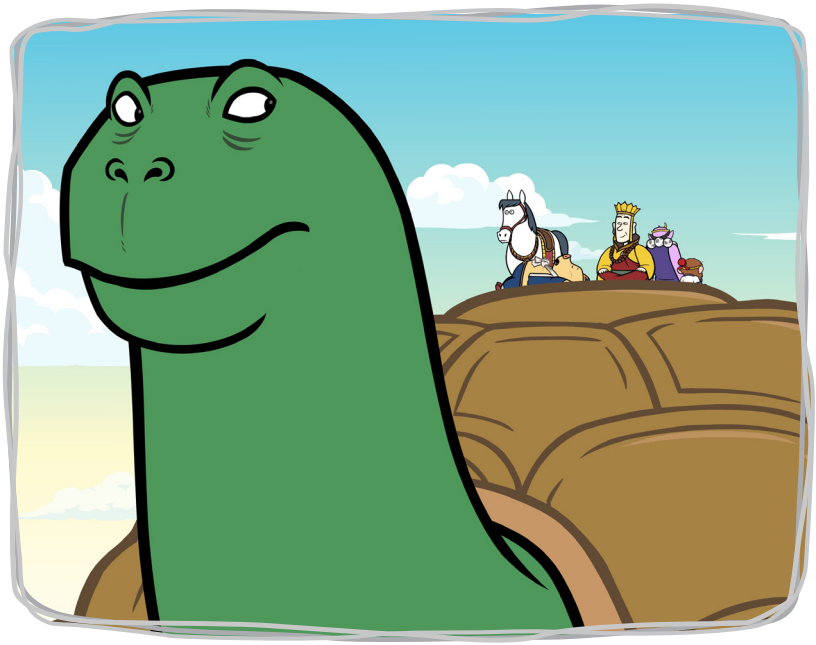
The villagers came out from behind the trees and waved.

"Good-bye!" called a woman.

"Please visit us on your way home!" shouted someone else.

"We will, I promise!" called the monk.

Soon the turtle was far from shore. Bajie

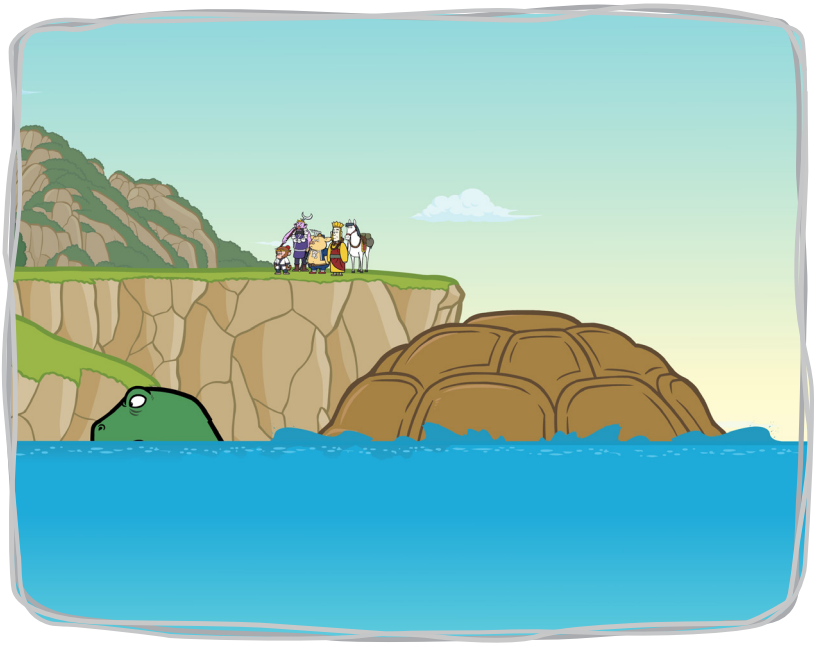


fell asleep.

The turtle glanced back at the Tang Monk. “Excuse me, but can you do me a favor?”

“Of course,” said the monk. “What do you need me to do?”

“I have been a good Buddhist for over a thousand years,” said the turtle. “But sadly I’m still just a turtle. Can you ask Buddha when I will be reborn as a human?”



The Tang Monk nodded. “I will ask him.”

A few hours later, the turtle reached the other side of the river. The travelers stepped onto dry land.

“Thank you,” said the Tang Monk.

“You’re welcome,” said the turtle. “Please don’t forget to ask Buddha about me.” The turtle disappeared under the water.

The Tang Monk climbed onto the horse,



and the group continued on the road.

As usual, Bajie soon started complaining. “I’m tired of walking already. I wish we could ride that turtle the whole way to the west.”

“Stop complaining,” said Wukong. “Be happy that the road is flat here.”

They walked for another couple of hours. The road started to go up a mountain, getting



steeper and steeper.

The pig moaned, “The road isn’t flat anymore!”

A cold wind whipped past them.

“Brr!” Wujing shivered.

“Look!” said the Tang Monk, pointing. Higher up the mountain was a large monastery. “Maybe we can rest there.”

Wukong looked at the monastery. A dark



mist hung over it.

The monkey shook his head. “That’s a bad place. We’re not going there.”

“It looks fine to me,” said the monk.

“I can see things that humans can’t see,” said Wukong. “And I see a dark mist hanging over that monastery. A demon could be in there.”

There was a sudden growling sound.



Wukong looked around to see what had caused it.

Bajie patted his stomach. “Sorry, I’m a bit hungry.”

“We’re all tired and hungry,” said the Tang Monk. “We should just go to that monastery.”

“No,” said Wukong sharply. “Stay here. I will find food for us.” He looked at the monk



and warned him again, “Do not go to that monastery!”

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